

INDIA'S INJURY CRISIS NEEDS MORE THAN A FITNESS FIX

Rising injuries have put India's player-management system under scrutiny, but the **concerns** extend beyond the Centre of Excellence and fitness.

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By the conclusion of the three-match One-Day International series in England in late July, the trend had snowballed to the point that even captain Shubman Gill could not hold back his frustration.

During the series, Jasprit Bumrah and Washington Sundar suffered injuries and were ruled out for the third ODI. Hamstring troubles had already sidelined Harshit Rana and Varun Chakaravathy during the preceding T20I series, while Nitish

Kumar Reddy was still in rehab following a quadriceps injury midway through the home series against Afghanistan in June.

But the most frustrating case was that of Hardik Pandya, who was at the BCCI Centre of Excellence (CoE) in Bengaluru, in recovery from a bout with back spasms during the Indian Premier League, when the board revealed the all-rounder would miss the upcoming games against Afghanistan due to a low-grade quadriceps sprain.

All six players were expected to play against England, a tour seen as

a crucial segue into India's preparations for the ODI World Cup in 2027. It was no surprise that Gill did not hold back.

"If you keep the World Cup as the goal where we have to play 11 matches in a row, and here we have players not being able to finish a two-to-three-match series. There is some limitation where our players are not able to play continuously; they play one or two matches, they suffer a niggle, and then we are forced to play a different combination which we originally did not plan to play.